Over the past decade, India's political landscape has been defined by a powerful convergence of Hindu nationalist rhetoric and display with claims of administrative efficiency, most visibly in the BJP-ruled states. This fusion has allowed the party's most ideologically assertive chief ministers to dominate public imagination in ways their counterparts on the opposite end of the spectrum have struggled to match. The latest INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll, by examining Indian federal politics through the lens of state leadership, sheds light on this dynamic. It reveals how voters across diverse states weigh governance, performance and ideology in shaping their perceptions.

Two distinct questions structured the exercise. First, respondents across the country were asked who they considered their favourite CM in India. This is a perception ranking, reflecting visibility, national resonance and image beyond state borders. Second, each state's respondents were asked to judge their own CM's performance, a more grounded, local assessment, anchored in everyday governance.

At the apex of national popularity stands Yogi Adityanath, the saffron-robed CM of Uttar Pradesh. His 36 per cent approval rating signifies the mainstreaming of muscular Hindu nationalism that once occupied the margins of Indian politics. Yogi's position, virtually unchanged over 11 consecutive surveys, suggests that his mix of religious symbolism, development and promises of law and order resonates far beyond India's most populous state. What makes this noteworthy is that he maintains this national prominence while simultaneously securing a respectable 40.4 per cent satisfaction rating within UP itself, a feat that eludes most other nationally recognised CMs.

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Consecutive surveys in which Yogi Adityanath has emerged as India's No. 1 CM

The phenomenon extends to Assam's Himanta Biswa Sarma, another BJP leader known for his hardline stance on issues of religious identity and demographic change. Despite experiencing a significant decline in his home state approval rating—from 55 per cent to 44.6 per cent over the past six months—Himanta still commands the highest satisfaction rating among CMs of major states. The erosion is notable ahead of next year's assembly election, suggesting fatigue or discontent despite his high-decibel politics. However, unlike Yogi, in the national popularity list, Himanta appears far down at No. 9, securing support of just over 2 per cent respondents. For both CMs, the divergence between national visibility and local acceptance illustrates the importance of maintaining a delicate balance between local bases and national attention.

The disconnect between national



ANI

BEST PERFORMING CMs (HOME STATE/ BIG*)

Respondents in every state were asked to rate their own CM

1 HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
Assam
44.6 [55]

2 VISHNU DEO SAI
Chhattisgarh
41.9 [39]

3 HEMANT SOREN
Jharkhand
41.9 [31]

4 BHUPENDRABHAI PATEL
Gujarat
40.7 [54]

5 YOGI ADITYANATH
Uttar Pradesh
40.4 [37]

6 MOHAN YADAV
Madhya Pradesh
39.2 [38]

7 N. CHANDRABABU NAIDU
Andhra Pradesh
38.1 [47]

8 MOHAN CHARAN MAJHI
Odisha
34.2 [39]

9 MAMATA BANERJEE
West Bengal
30.1 [46]

10 BHAGWANT SINGH MANN
Punjab
29.9 [17]

Respondents were asked to evaluate the performance of their own CM. For instance, 44.6% respondents of the total of 6,755 from Assam said they were satisfied with Himanta Biswa Sarma while 41.9% of the 1,529 respondents from Chhattisgarh expressed satisfaction at Vishnu Deo Sai's performance

States with more than 10 Lok Sabha seats

All figures in %; rest, others; Aug. '25 figures in bold red, Feb. '25 in [ ]